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KF Introduction to NHG

Chapter 3: *The Tyranny of the Should*¹

Let's return to Nancy's story and learn a little more about the history of Karis Fellowships, which may help you trust in the value of your own efforts toward recovering your real self.

In 1977, Nancy returned to the United States from the mission field deeply troubled about her inability to sincerely love herself and others. Through a series of astonishing miracles, God led her to a Christian college in southern California where she met a man who did not conform to the conventions of her Christian upbringing. He taught her that the only productive goal for a Christian is to live consistently without fear and in agape love. The Apostle Paul wrote about this love in a letter to the Corinthian church, and believe me, the Corinthians were just as confused about love as our culture is today. The love that Paul described has nothing to do with our emotions and everything to do with our choices. He said that without this love our work is nothing, we accomplish nothing, and, even more pitiful, we are nothing. Nancy felt deeply convicted about the need to change the direction of her Christian life, and with God's help, she began that very difficult work. She withdrew from church activities and dedicated the next two decades of her life to learning to love.

Nancy became increasingly aware that most of her choices were motivated by a kind of self-created legal system full of claims, shoulds, and taboos. This personal law dictated what she *should* do, think, and feel, and imposed taboos that prescribed what she *shouldn't* do, think, and feel. Although her law provided some sort of compass by which she navigated her life, it also stifled every real thought, emotion, desire, and delight, and generated a lot of self-hate. She lacked the inner peace that supports exploration and personal development; all her energy was devoted to obeying her loveless law and managing her anxiety. Her commitment to this law of shoulds and taboos was the source of her inflexibility, impatience, and unloving reactions. She was more committed to adhering to her own law than to following the Lord of love.

Most students find these chapters about shoulds and claims very troubling. They fear that if they were to walk away from their beliefs about how they and others should act, they would be overrun by chronic confusion and insecurity. Perhaps you are asking yourself, "If I give up my shoulds and claims, how will I motivate myself or others?" Letting go of our shoulds and claims is part of losing our lives for Christ's sake, and losing our lives isn't easy. It is scary work and requires courage, dedication, and endurance.

God is eager to help us move away from law and learn to live in love. Love becomes the great motivation for those who have been rescued from law. In Karis Fellowships, we help each other learn how to love as the Bible teaches us. We stir each other up to love and good works.² What is the greatest commandment? It is to love the Lord your God with all your heart, soul, mind, and strength, and the next is just like it: to love your neighbor as yourself. Jesus teaches us that loving God, loving others, and loving our real self are synonymous. As God's children, love is not only our greatest motivation – it is our greatest achievement.

¹ Karen Horney, *Neurosis and Human Growth* (New York: Norton, 1991).

² Heb. 10:24.

Now let's finish Nancy's story. Soon after arriving at college, Nancy met her husband, Chuck, and together they began the work of learning to apply real love in their lives. After over forty years of marriage and through many difficulties and joys, they are still exploring the potential of that great adventure, an adventure that continues to develop their real self and build their trust in the Person of God.

When you download your next reading guide, print off the KF document **Are You in Love or Pride?** Refer to it regularly as you begin to examine your life and your choices in the light of real love.

KF Facilitator Guide

Chapter 3: *The Tyranny of the Should*¹

1:00 Weekly (go straight to questions)/0:00 Weekend Intensive (WI)

Lead Facilitator starts the recording by pressing *9.

“Welcome everyone to chapter 3 of *Neurosis and Human Growth*. We will begin our study by reading Nancy’s introduction to the chapter.”

Support Facilitator reads the Introduction.

Lead Facilitator: “Thank you. Let’s go to Presenting. When you give us your name and location, you might also share something that you do to take care of yourself. We can start with those living furthest east and move west. I will begin.”

“My name is _____ and I am calling from _____. To take care of myself, I _____.”

- Facilitators open the [NHG Spreadsheet](#) to record attendance and homework completion.
- Each facilitator makes a list of the names of students as they present.
- Lead facilitator prepares group divisions while students present.
- Lead facilitator assigns groups and says, “To leave the main group, press *3 and then, when prompted, enter your group number. To return to the main group, press *3*.”
- Each facilitator asks, “Is there anyone who has not filled out their reading guide?”
- Each facilitator assigns the first 10 questions to two students, 5 questions each. Continue to answer the questions in sets of 10, assigning 5 questions per student in rotation.

Question 21 is open to the group, and there are many possible answers.

1:20/0:15 WI

1. On what two worlds do neurotics focus in trying to actualize their idealized self? (64.1-2)
 - A. **Outside world: in achievements, in the glory of success or power or triumph**
 - B. **Inner world, within himself: he molds himself into a supreme being of his own making**
2. Of what do the inner dictates comprise? (65.2)

Of all that the neurotic should be able to do, to be, to feel, to know – and taboos on how and what the neurotic should not do, be, feel, and know.

I should have an answer for every question – a great answer!

I should be good, merciful, etc.

I should always win.

Nancy said: “I read a book about experiencing God and it told me that if I see God doing anything, I should join in. That idea was overwhelming because it presents a million shoulds!”
3. What necessity do neurotics feel and what is their conviction? (65.4).

They feel the necessity to turn into their idealized self, and their conviction is that they can do so.

This is especially true of smart people who are used to accomplishing and doing quickly whatever they put their minds to. It is also true of people who are powerfully motivated by imagination; if they can imagine it, then they *should* do it.

4. What are the two characteristics of the drive for actualization? (66.1-3).

- A. **A disregard for feasibility**
- B. **A complete disregard for the conditions under which demands on the self could be fulfilled**

Feasibility means that circumstances, personal attributes, training, and resources are supporting our goals.

Horney's gives the example of a physician realizing he can't carry on working nine-hour days and also have a full social life while continuing at the same pace.

Dr. Horney writes that progress of recovery is not dependent on intelligence, background, or theology but on the patients' ability to deal with the emotional forces operating within them and on their capacity to be straight and to assume responsibility for themselves.

We might know that it is feasible to change our lives but then disregard the conditions under which we might heal. Changing our lives takes time, sustained effort, and help.

5. To neurotics, recognizing their neurotic claims seems to be the equivalent of what? (67.1)

To them it is the equivalent of having outgrown them.

Jesus said: "You know these things, blessed are ye if you do them." And James teaches, "Be doers of the word, not hearers only." The neurotic thinks: "I know these things and I am blessed because I know them." "I hear these things, and that should be enough to change my life."

6. The inner dictates operate with supreme disregard for what? (67.2)

A disregard for one's own psychic condition – for what we can feel or do as we are at present.

What Dr. Horney means by psychic is our own inner world. Most of us ignore our psychic world. We only feel the feelings, or think the thoughts, but cannot observe ourselves long enough to see the patterns or ask if we could do something different. We are not trained to explore the basic problems, and in fact, as neurotics we do not even wish to recognize them.

7. What is the logic behind the neurotic's refusal to examine existing conditions? (68.2)

Nothing should be, or is, impossible for the neurotic.

An author writes: I should write, but do not want to look at the reasons why I am not writing. I could examine existing conditions and then set some goals, re-examine my goals in a few days or weeks, and re-set some goals according to realities, but I don't want to. It is easier to believe that nothing is impossible for me rather than admit how hard this is.

8. What is a matter-of-fact attitude toward the past? (69.2)

To admit that early influences could not fail to mold me in an unfavorable way.

To recognize that my origins DO disturb my present and future life. I had better muster my energies and make the effort to outgrow them.

9. In view of our neurotic difficulties at the time of our "failures", what might we recognize? (69.3).

We might recognize that we may actually have done the best that we could at that time

Others may also be doing the best that they can at the time. We can offer compassion.

One student said: “We were obviously doing the best we could because look at where our search has brought us—to KF!”

10. In what two ways does the neurotic try to overcome present shortcomings? (70.2-3)

- A. **By spiriting away difficulties using the imagination.**
- B. **By dint of sheer willpower.**

A member talked about running on a broken ankle. He didn’t know it was broken, but he also wanted to show his body that his will was stronger than his body’s complaints.

11. Using willpower is fine if the person is also showing what? (70.4)

Showing an equal interest in understanding the implications and sources of their troubles.

In KF we grow out of the problem rather than suppressing or controlling it. Suppressing and controlling wastes so much energy!

12. If the neurotic is using only willpower to overcome disturbances and difficulties, what is sure to happen? (70.4–71.1)

Willpower alone drives difficulties underground where they continue to operate in a disguised form.

Dreams will often reveal the continuing conflict through images that are symbolic of what is being suppressed.

1:25/0:25 WI

13. Do most neurotic disturbances respond to strenuous efforts at control? (71.2)

No, most neurotic disturbances resist even the more strenuous efforts or control.

One writer claimed that the effort to resist an addiction is part of the addiction itself. We must find another way.

Most KF members have worked very hard in the church and in spiritual disciplines yet could not overcome their neurotic disturbances.

14. Why is depression so much more painful for neurotics? (71.2)

Because neurotics think, “I should be able to master this,” and see their depression as a visible sign of their lack of omnipotence.

15. On whom had Horney’s client projected her expectation of herself? (71.2)

She had projected her expectation of herself onto her therapist (Horney).

Some people have felt judged by the KF training because when they begin to tackle their own shoulds, they externalize these shoulds onto KF.

When we think that someone else is judging us, we might consider whether we are actually judging ourselves.

It is especially destructive when we impose our expectations of ourselves onto our children.

16. At what do the inner dictates aim? (72.2)

Immediate and absolute perfection. They aim at making the imperfection disappear, or making it appear as if the particular perfection were attained.

This demand for perfection makes it difficult for those in relationship with us to ask for what they want, because when they do ask, we react with self-judgment for not having perfectly met our inner dictate to foresee and provide what others want or need without being asked. The distressing issue then is about our hurt pride and not about actually serving the other person.

Students say:

"I made my wife a special breakfast. When she asked for the salt, I felt that I had failed. I wanted to believe that I had done everything perfectly for my own satisfaction and pride. She shouldn't want salt!"

The understanding of inner dictates might help us understand what James means when he writes, "For whoever keeps the whole law and yet stumbles in one point, he has become guilty of all" (James 2:10).

"I get euphoric when others say that they see a perfection in my life, even if it isn't real. It is just an impression and illusion, but I get high on it."

17. What happens when inner demands are externalized? (72.2)

What a person actually is, and even what he suffers, becomes irrelevant. Only what is visible to others creates intense worries.

When we try to appear mature or skilled, it makes real change difficult. We get stuck in only appearing perfect because if we changed, it would prove that we weren't perfect.

Ministry! The great appearance opportunity.

When we begin the laborious effort of changing our lives, we often find that the anticipation of the pain was much worse than the pain itself. The idealized self will imagine the process to be much more painful than it actually is in order to discourage us from making the effort to change and grow.

18. What do the "shoulds" lack? (72.3)

The shoulds lack the moral seriousness of genuine ideals.

19. Even moral shoulds are permeated by what spirit? (73.1)

They are permeated by the spirit of arrogance, and they aim at enhancing the neurotic's search for glory and making him godlike.

We create a counterfeit to normal moral strivings with a simplistic legal system of just deciding and judging what is right and wrong.

20. In your opinion, is it moral to be dishonest in order to look good?

No.

- Our system of shoulds is the neurotic counterfeit to authentic moral strivings

- It is immoral to be dishonest in our relationships and with ourselves
- Choosing good manners is moral, but judging that everyone should have good manners is not
- We are not here to impose our conditions on others, but to be honest with ourselves

21. Compare the characteristics of coercive shoulds with genuine standards. Refer to the book and draw on your own experience. (72.5–74.1)

Open this question to the group.

Coercive Shoulds (inner dictates)

- Immediate and absolute perfection
- Weakens us; enslaving
- Perfection is always around the corner
- Enormous tension
- Quantity
- Determined by unconscious arrogance
- Counterfeit to normal moral strivings
- Make-believe
- Pushy and forceful
- Quick retribution if not met
- Shock/collapse/anxiety
- Imagined standard of performance
- Sense of obligation
- Act to avoid retribution
- I am a Christian because I believe
- Afraid of truth
- Tries to control
- Imaginary achievements
- Without limitations
- Influenced by external factors
- Slavery

Genuine Standards

- Real change – what I am is relevant, important
- Strengthens us with congruence
- Genuine standards increasingly actualized
- Rest
- Quality
- Determined by personal growth
- True moral strivings to become a better person
- Genuine
- Voluntary
- Self-awareness and compassion
- Peace
- Doing our best and being content
- Motivated by desire
- Act out of genuine desire or choice
- I act like a Christian because I am
- Rejoices in truth
- Tries to let go of control
- Genuine achievements based on practical effort
- Honoring limitations
- The decision is our own to do what we deem right
- Liberty

22. Why does the reaction of anxiety escape attention? (74.3)

Because the customary defenses against anxiety are set going instantaneously.

These defenses are coping mechanisms to maintain psychic integrity. Rather than using these customary defenses, we could look at recent events in our lives and then notice our behavior. We can then consider what inner dictate we have failed to fulfill.

1:30/0:35 WI

23. What can throw us out of gear? (75.2)

When we are caught between two contradictory shoulds.

I should practice Christian disciplines all of the time, but I should also support my football team.
I should be right and no one should question me, but I should also be humble and accept instruction.
I should be assertive and authentic, but I should also be kind to others.

It is a wonderful indication of growth when we experience a transition from a should to real motivation.

24. How are the inner dictates primarily determined? (76.1)

By the greatest appeal life holds for the individual, whether mastery, love, or freedom.

25. What is crucial for the expansive type? (76.2)

Mastery of life.

26. What is sufficient for expansive types? (76.3)

That in their minds they are supremely fearless or honest.

27. What solves all problems for the self-effacing type? (76.4)

Love.

28. What is the foremost conscious experience for the self-effacing type? (77.1)

Self-criticism and a feeling of guilt for not being the supreme being.

29. What idea appeals more than anything else to the resigned type? (77.3)

Freedom.

30. Of the three neurotic types, resigned types are most prone to rebel against what? (77.3)

Their inner tyranny.

Resigned types are hypersensitive to any feeling of being coerced or imposed on.

A student said: "What I thought was my greatest strength – my ability to stand in a kind of aloof dispassionate faith – turned out to be this cluster of neurotic needs. I'm very glad to have a Savior."

31. Can a person who usually complies with their shoulds have a rebellious phase? (77.5)

Yes, and this rebellion is usually directed against external restrictions.

32. Where does a great deal of the process of grappling with shoulds take place? (78.2)

Externally, between self and others.

Example: If a wife believes that she should have more status in the community, she will make relentless demands on her husband to get a promotion or make more money.

A student said: "I thought my wife was demanding from me an immediate response, but actually I was making demands on myself."

33. On whom do neurotics primarily impose their standards and make relentless demands for perfection? (78.2)

On others.

They do not insist on general perfection but on their particular norms being measured up to.

Students say:

- "I tend to hold myself to high standards, but I often fail, so I impose those standards on my husband."

- “I am hard on my mother for not living up to my shoulds. I want her to have my shoulds and live up to them. She has her own set of shoulds that are not valuable to me. My lack of compassion for her reality creates lots of conflict for me, and I take it out on her.”

1:35/0:45 WI

34. Neurotics may believe that their expectations of themselves are coming from whom? (78.3)

From others.

We think that others expect of us what we expect of ourselves

Jesus taught that when we see a twig in someone else’s eye, we need to first deal with the beam in our own eye. What we want to change in others is probably reflecting what we wish we could change in ourselves.

35. In what two ways do neurotics respond to expectations? (79.1)

- A. They try to anticipate or guess at others’ expectations and are eager to live up to them.**
- B. They feel that other people are imposing upon them, meddling in their affairs, pushing them, or coercing them.**

We could acknowledge our lack of omniscience and ask others for what they want, but we are actually afraid of what they might say. We would rather guess what they want and feel good about meeting that imagined want than suffer the hurt pride of being wrong or criticized. Also, we are afraid that if we learn the truth about what they want, we might have to do something about it, and that would feel like an imposition. It is like playing mental chess at all times—it’s exhausting.

36. Overreaction to requests can lead us to recognize what? (79.2)

Our own inner demands.

It is very helpful to examine reactions that are out of proportion to a request. In KF, we can use the Shoulds Worksheet to help us examine our reactions.

37. What feeling do the shoulds produce? (81.2)

Strain.

Students say: “Before I started working on myself through the book group, I didn’t know how much strain was in my life. It’s like going to the chiropractor and after the adjustment being aware that I had been in a lot of pain.”

38. To what does the externalization of shoulds always contribute? (81.3)

To disturbances in human relations.

Neurotics are too harsh, too compliant, or too uninterested to have healthy relationships.

39. In relationships, what is the most general disturbance caused by externalized shoulds? (81.3)

Hypersensitivity to criticism.

This is not only criticism of ourselves, but also any criticism of something we believe, think, feel, or adhere to. For example, we may be reactive and volatile, and may suddenly feel unsafe if someone questions our political party, our family, our theology, etc.

If you offer criticism to a neurotic, their tendency might be to counter your criticism by attacking you with criticism. That relieves their sense of threat, and it feels like it cancels out your criticism. They restore their pride by putting you down.

We can learn to be compassionate about the reactions of others. They too are living under the great burden of shoulds.

40. For what do neurotics hate themselves? (81.3)

For any lagging behind their self-imposed standards.

41. What do the shoulds further impair? (81.4)

Shoulds impair the spontaneity of feeling, wishes, thoughts, and beliefs – i.e., the ability to feel our own feelings etc., and express them.

Shoulds dictate what we can allow ourselves to be aware of, what evidence in our lives we will accept.

42. What are we accustomed to think that we cannot control? (82.1)

We think that we cannot control feelings but only behavior.

There is often a distrust of our feelings because we believe that we cannot control them. We might believe that emotions aren't important, that they'll lead us astray, and that they are distressing and uncomfortable. But we can actually manage our feelings and allow them to enrich our lives.

Perhaps you feel that you need to fix or change people. In KF, we create a culture of leaving the responsibility for change to each member. We offer members tools to fix *themselves*, and we support those who are willing to take up that responsibility.

43. What does the “magic wand” of our imagination do for us? (82.1)

It evaporates the border line between what we should feel and what we do feel.

We then consciously believe or feel what we should believe and feel without any regard for authenticity.

Others, especially children, can often sense that our feelings and beliefs are artificial and, therefore, vulnerable to hurt pride. Our inauthenticity makes it difficult, if not impossible, for others to trust us. We are fundamentally untrustworthy.

44. What can we expect when pseudo-feelings are shaken? (82.2)

We can expect go through a period of bewildering uncertainty which will be painful but constructive.

1:40/0:50 WI

45. What was the patient able to see for the first time? (82.4)

The patient was able to see her inability to want anything or feel anything.

When we allow the Lord to start changing our lives, it might feel like the bulldozers of the Holy Spirit are knocking down the little rickety house of our idealized self – a house of cards with only a pseudo infrastructure, a house built on the sand.

It takes a lot more work to build a house on the rock than to build a house on the sand. We want the

easy work of building on the sand but then blame everything and everyone else for our chronic instability and pervasive sense of insecurity.

A student said: "I decided that all my helping others was neurotic. I chose not help people until I felt like it. I kept working on my issues. One day, I spontaneously offered help to someone else and have happily continued helping others since."

46. The ability to create make-believe feelings is most striking in which kind of people? (83.2)

In those whose idealized image lies in the direction of goodness, love, and saintliness.

These people depend on their feelings to give them a sense of identity. The quality of their actual feelings makes them doubt their worth or contribution, so they have to make up feelings to help them feel worthwhile.

47. What are the characteristics of made-to-order feelings? (83.2-3)

- A. No depth or sustaining power**
- B. Disappear or change easily**
- C. Massive pretense with very little that is genuine**
- D. Give the impression of something unsubstantial, elusive, or phony**
- E. An irruptive anger is often the only feeling that is really fair.**

48. What other feelings can be exaggerated? (83.4)

Callousness and ruthlessness.

Though we try to be analytical and objective, we are still motivated by strong feelings that influence our selection of data. That is why we are taught to divest ourselves of feelings in academia, theology, politics, or science. But if we aren't working on our recovery from neurosis, we will always default to those strong feelings and our analysis will be biased.

Extreme feelings are the result of stories that seem very rational in the moment but are actually created to relieve our anxiety and tension and to avoid inner conflict.

49. When inner commands are contradictory, what results? (84.2)

- **Inconsistent self-evaluation**
- **Emotional deadness**
- **Taboos creating pervasive inhibitions**
- **Pervasive claims**

Many things contribute to emotional deadness, such as emotional exhaustion, contradictory shoulds, neurotoxins, and actual physical overload.

An example of a contradictory should: "I should take care of myself, but that is what pitiful people do. I must not be pitiful, so I will put a check on any self-care."

50. Why are neurotics unable to consider relinquishing their shoulds? (84.4)

They feel that without their shoulds, they would or could not do anything.

If we were to relinquish our shoulds, we would not be able to externalize our shoulds and make other people do things.

As we get healthier, we can be motivated by wanting a certain outcome. We might begin replacing our shoulds with the question, “What outcome do I want?”

51. What makes the enormous coercive power of the shoulds a “regime of terror”? (85.2)

The threat of punitive self-hate that lurks behind the shoulds.

In KF, we train our courage so that we can tackle our self-hate. Self-hate is not just directed inwardly toward ourselves, it is directed externally as well. Perhaps we have experienced the hostility of someone who is actually hating themselves because of their own inadequacies.

God has given us the 10 commandments, but we have created for ourselves a gazillion other commandments that we hope will carry us into our idealized glory.

Students say:

- “Extraordinary goals and expectations made me feel extraordinary. They made me drag myself forward. Since KF training I live so differently. My goals are quite different.”
- “Someone said that expectations are premeditated resentment. When I or others fail in my expectations, my resentment feels justified.”
- “Without expectations of what should be, we could go through life full of gratitude for what is.”
- “God created us for love and joy and to be real and have glorious possibilities. In Jesus we can access that potential.”
- “People came to Jesus out of desperation. People are almost always motivated by desperation to change their lives.”

At first, we are distressed by the amount of energy we are wasting on our shoulds and claims. In KF, we start to understand that we actually have a lot of energy but are just throwing it away. We can learn to access that energy and redirect it productively.

Example to show the contrast between a should and a claim:

Should: I should be able to hit the golf ball so that it goes exactly where I want it to go.

Externalized should: I am angry at the ball for going into the sand pit. The ball should go where I want it to go.

Claim: I am entitled to always be successful in golf games. When I am not successful it’s unfair. The course must be badly maintained, and I don’t have expensive golf-clubs like those other guys.

1:45 All weekly subgroups return to main group for discussion and closing by pressing *3*.

0:55 WI students take a five-minute break. Break-out room (subgroup) facilitator returns to the main meeting (*3*) to report attendance and homework, then goes back to the subgroup and waits for the next facilitator to arrive before signing off. Facilitator, do not turn off the recording.

Lead Facilitator: When we listen to our language, we might notice how often we use the word “should”. One of our KF suggestions is to try replacing the word “should” with “could” or “might” and then notice the difference in your body tension and general feelings. One NHG student said: “Since the last study I am noticing how often I use the word should. It is in a spirit of defeat.”

2:00 (approx.) Stop the recording. (*9 then 1)

All facilitators, please stay after the meeting to confirm student attendance and homework completion on the [NHG Attendance Spreadsheet](#).

Lead Facilitator: “Are there any comments or questions?”

¹ This reading guide refers to the 1991 edition of *Neurosis and Human Growth: The Struggle Toward Self-Realization* by Karen Horney, published by W.W. Norton and Company Inc. New York.